
Isabella Leonarda

1620–1704, ITALIAN

At the age of 16, Isabella Leonarda, a member of a local aristocratic family, entered a convent in Novara, northwest Italy, where she spent the rest of her life.

During this period of almost 70 years she became head of the convent and one of the leading female composers of her time, with about 200 works to her credit. They are mainly sacred vocal works of various kinds, but she also wrote secular instrumental pieces, including a set of four sonatas that are thought to be the first sonatas ever published by a woman (the majority of her work was published in handsome editions during her lifetime, mainly in Bologna but also sometimes in Milan and Venice). Leonarda confined her composing to periods allocated to rest so that it did not distract her from her normal duties as a nun.

KEY WORKS: Ave suavis dilectio (Hail, Sweet Love), 1676; Ave Regina caelorum (Hail, Queen of Heaven), 1684; Sonata for Solo Violin and Continuo, 1693

Dieterich Buxtehude